

UNIT 2

Metamorphosis

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Ammu looks around the spot, worried. She runs in all directions until she gets too tired. When she stops, she sees a man coming out of the darkness of the forest. The man is old and tall.

1

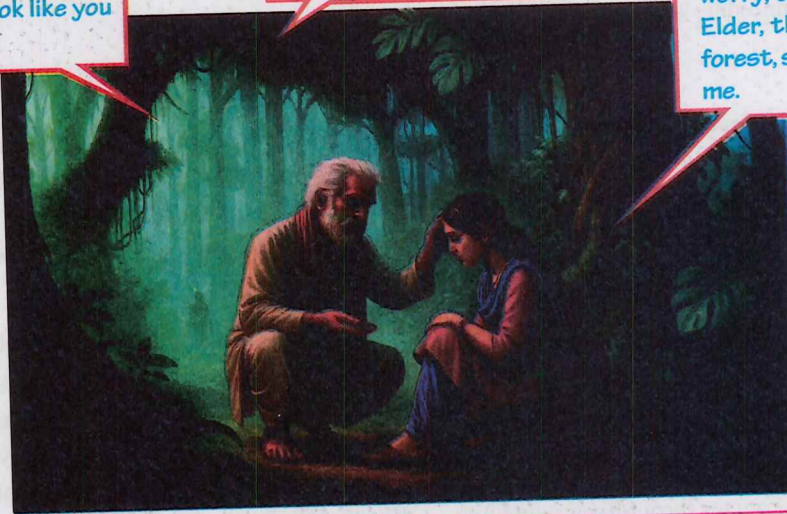
The man: You look like you are lost, child.

2

Ammu: My... My friend... Abhi...

3

The man: Oh, the boy? Don't worry, child. He is safe. Our Elder, the protector of the forest, saved him. Come with me.



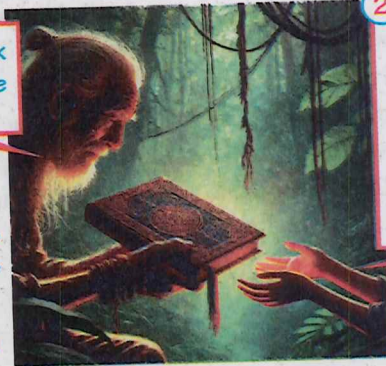
The man takes Ammu to his forest village. Inside a straw hut, Abhi is sleeping on a cot made of jute. He is a little hurt from the escape. The villagers applied some herbal medicine to his wounds. Ammu and Abhi feel extremely happy to see each other. Ammu helps Abhi to recover. Before leaving, they go to thank the protector of the forest.

1

Ammu and Abhi: We thank you for helping us. It's time for us to go home.

2

The Elder: We are all the children of Mother Earth. It is our duty to help one another. We will give you food and water for your journey. Take this book too, as a gift. May the Elements of the Earth be with you.



Ammu opens the book. The first page says: "If we protect Nature, Nature protects us."

Abhi: What's that you are reading from the book, Ammu?

Ammu: Chief Seattle's Letter.

Abhi: Come on, let's read it.

Motivation is like fire - unless you keep adding fuel to it, it dies - Shiv Khera

Chief Seattle's Letter

Chief Seattle

(This letter emerged in the mid-1850s during a period of rapid U.S. expansion. At the time, the U.S. government, under President Franklin Pierce, was pressuring Native American tribes in the Pacific Northwest to relinquish their lands to accommodate settlers moving westward.)

The Lesson

"The President in Washington sends word that he wishes to buy our land. But how can you buy or sell the sky? The land? The idea is strange to us. If we do not own the freshness of the air and the sparkle of the water, how can you buy them?

Every part of the earth is sacred to my people. Every shining pine needle, every sandy shore, every mist in the dark woods, every meadow, every humming insect. All are holy in the memory and experience of my people. We know the sap which courses through the trees as we know the blood that courses through our veins. We are part of the earth and it is part of us. The perfumed flowers are our sisters. The bear, the deer, the great eagle, these are our brothers. The rocky crests, the dew in the meadow, the body heat of the pony, and man all belong to the same family.

The shining water that moves in the streams and rivers is not just water, but the blood of our ancestors. If we sell you our land, you must remember that it is sacred. Each glossy reflection in the clear waters of the lakes tells of events and memories in the life of my people.

The water's murmur is the voice of my father's father. The rivers are our brothers. They quench our thirst. They carry our canoes and feed our children. So, you must give the rivers the kindness that you would give any brother.

If we sell you our land, remember that the air is precious to us, that the air shares its spirit with all the life that it supports. The wind also gives our children the spirit of life. So, if we sell our land, you must keep it apart and sacred, as a place where man can go to taste the wind that is sweetened by the meadow flowers.

Will you teach your children what we have taught our children? That the earth is our mother? What befalls the earth befalls all the sons of the earth. This we know: the earth does not belong to man, man belongs to the earth. All things are connected like the blood that unites us all. Man did not weave the web of life, he is merely a strand in it. Whatever he does to the web, he does to himself. One thing we know: our God is also your God. The earth is precious to him and to harm the earth is to heap contempt on its creator.

Pause and Ponder

Ammu: Our generation and our leaders have a lot to learn from Chief Seattle.

Abhi: Yes! Look how he treats nature as Mother! In the race towards technology, we are going far from nature!

Pause and Ponder

Ammu: Abhi, look how much he loves all the creatures of nature! He genuinely wants all the trees, animals, and rivers be safe and healthy.

Abhi: And he calls all of us as brothers. He cares for all humans too.

Your destiny is a mystery to us. What will happen when the buffalo are all slaughtered? The wild horses tamed? What will happen when the secret corners of the forest are heavy with the scent of many men and the view of the ripe hills is blotted with talking wires? Where will the thicket be? Gone! Where will the eagle be? Gone! And what is to say goodbye to the swift pony and then hunt? The end of living and the beginning of survival.

When the last red man has vanished with this wilderness, and his memory is only the shadow of a cloud moving across the prairie, will these shores and forests still be here? Will there be any of the spirit of my people left?

We love this earth as a newborn loves its mother's heartbeat. So, if we sell you our land, love it as we have loved it. Care for it, as we have cared for it. Hold in your mind the memory of the land as it is when you receive it. Preserve the land for all children, and love it, as God loves us.

As we are part of the land, you too are part of the land. This earth is precious to us. It is also precious to you. One thing we know - there is only one God. No man, be he Red man or White man, can be apart. We ARE all brothers after all."

Theme Shopping for Students

Below are the key themes and objectives to learn from "Chief Seattle's Letter". As you understand each one, mark it off.

- Have you learnt how Indigenous tribes live sustainably and respect nature through traditional practices?
- Who is Chief Seattle? Do you understand his view of nature?
- Have you explored the contributions of Indian environmentalists?
- Can you explain why biodiversity is essential for a balanced ecosystem?
- Have you ever thought of practical solutions to reduce waste and protect the environment?

About the Author

Chief Seattle Chief Seattle (also known as Seathl), was a respected leader of the Suquamish and Duwamish tribes who lived on the islands of the Puget Sound in what is now Washington State. As a young warrior, Chief Seattle was known for his courage and daring leadership. The present seaport city of Seattle is named after this native leader.



The Summary

Chief Seattle's speech, often mistakenly referred to as "Chief Seattle's Letter," is a deeply emotional and thoughtful response to the U.S. government's request to buy the land of his tribe. Though no official written record of his words exists, the speech was later transcribed and adapted by various authors. In it, he speaks about the spiritual connection his people have with the land and expresses his sorrow over losing not just their home but also their way of life.

Chief Seattle explains that, for his people, the Earth is not something to own or use carelessly. Every part of nature—rivers, trees, animals, and mountains—is considered sacred and alive. He compares these elements of nature to family members, and emphasises that harming them is like harming oneself. He points out that the white settlers see land as a resource to buy and sell, but for Native Americans, it is a gift that sustains all life and deserves respect.

A key message in the letter is about interconnectedness. Chief Seattle warns that everything in nature is connected, like a web. If one part is damaged, the entire web suffers. He believes that the white settlers' lack of respect for nature will lead to environmental destruction, which will hurt everyone, including the settlers themselves.

Despite his sadness, Chief Seattle acknowledges that change is inevitable. He mourns the loss but hopes the settlers will treat the land with respect and remember its sacredness. His words carry a universal message: humans must live in harmony with nature, or they will face the consequences of their actions.

The letter is more than a historical document; it is a timeless reminder of the importance of protecting the environment and honouring the natural world. It teaches us to be mindful of our actions and to care for the Earth, not just for ourselves but for future generations.

Glossary

- **Ancestors /ˈænsəstə(r)z/ (noun):** People in one's family who lived a long time ago
Usage: His ancestors had come to Andhra Pradesh from Telangana.
- **Blot /blɒt/ (noun):** A stain
Usage: He tried to remove the blot from his shirt.
- **Befall /brˈfɔːl/ (verb):** To happen to, especially something bad
Usage: We prayed that no harm would befall the travellers.
- **Contempt /kənˈtempt/ (noun):** The feeling that a person or a thing is worthless
Usage: She spoke with contempt in her voice.
- **Crest /krest/ (noun):** The top of a hill/mountain
Usage: He stood on the crest of the hill, surveying the land.

- **Meadow** /'medəu/ (noun): A field of grass, often for hay
Usage: The cows grazed peacefully in the meadow.
- **Murmur** /'mɜ:mə(r)/ (noun): A low, continuous sound
Usage: She could hear the murmur of the river as she fell asleep.
- **Prairie** /'preəri/ (noun): A large open area of grassland.
Usage: The prairie stretched as far as the eye could see.
- **Precious** /'preʃəs/ (adjective): Of great value; not to be wasted or treated carelessly
Usage: Her grandmother's ring was her most precious possession.
- **Quench** /kwentʃ/ (verb): To satisfy thirst
Usage: A glass of water will quench your thirst.
- **Slaughter** /'slə:tər/ (noun): The killing of animals for food or a large-scale killing
Usage: The slaughter of innocent civilians shocked the world.
- **Thicket** /'θɪkt/ (noun): A dense group of bushes or trees
Usage: They lost their way in the thicket.
- **Vanish** /'væniʃ/ (verb): To disappear suddenly
Usage: The magician made the rabbit vanish.
- **Wilderness** /'wildərnɪs/ (noun): An uncultivated, uninhabited region
Usage: The wilderness was teeming with wildlife.

Contextual Questions

Annotate the following lines in the given pattern

- a. Identify the lesson and name the writer of the given lines.
- b. Discuss the context of the lines and appreciate them critically in about 75 words.
 1. If we do not own the freshness of the air and the sparkle of the water, how can you buy them?
 2. The earth does not belong to man, man belongs to the earth.
 3. The earth is precious to him and to harm the earth is to heap contempt on its Creator.
 4. One thing we know - there is only one God. No man, be he Red man or White man, can be apart. We are all brothers after all.

Questions

Answer the following questions in about 150 words each

1. How does Chief Seattle describe the relationship between Native Americans and Nature?
2. Chief Seattle mentions that "all things are connected." How does this concept apply to environmental issues today?
3. How are Chief Seattle's words relevant to current discussions about climate change and environmental responsibility?

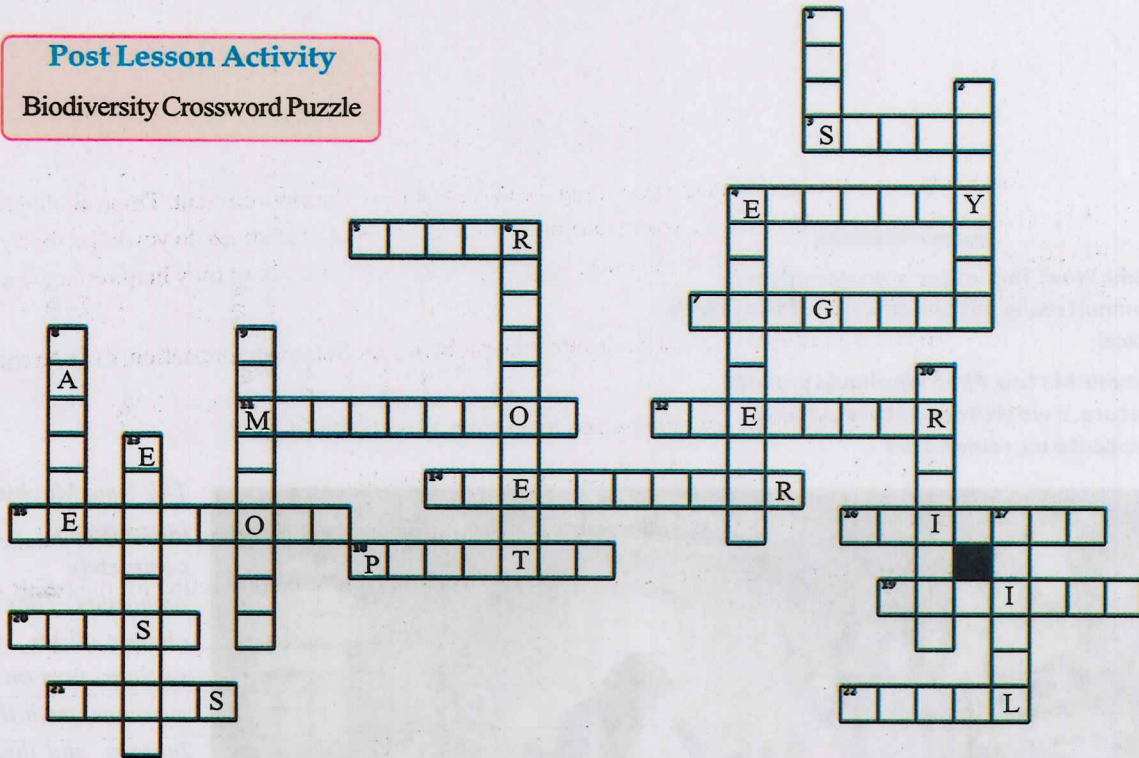
Creative Writing

Using the hints provided, write at least ten lines, expanding the ideas into complete sentences. Be creative!

Letter to the Future

Idea: Write a letter to future generations describing the current state of the environment. Think about issues like pollution, climate change, and the loss of natural habitat. What kind of changes do you hope for by the time they are alive? What steps should they take to protect the planet? How can they help reduce waste, save water, and protect animals?

- Hints**
- **First** – Describe the current environmental problems: pollution, deforestation, melting ice, etc.
 - **But** – Express hope for change and the power of future actions.
 - **Then** – Share your hopes for a cleaner, healthier world.
 - **Later** – Give advice on reducing waste, conserving water, and supporting sustainable practices.
 - **Finally** – Encourage future generations to stay strong and keep protecting for the Earth.

Post Lesson Activity**Biodiversity Crossword Puzzle**

Follow the following clues and complete the puzzle

ACROSS

3. What do trees provide to keep areas cool
4. Study of ecosystems and their relationships
5. A large flowing body of water
7. Coastal trees that protect against erosion and storms
11. Seasonal movement of animals for survival
12. An animal that hunts others for food
14. Type of ecosystem found in rivers and lakes
15. To break down naturally into organic matter
16. Overall weather patterns in a region
18. Material we should reduce to save the planet
19. The natural home or environment of an animal or plant
20. Common plant in fields, eaten by herbivores
21. Lungs of the Earth, providing oxygen and homes for animals
22. A marine organism that forms reefs

DOWN

1. Important pollinators for plants and crops
2. A way to reuse materials and reduce waste
4. Threatened by extinction
6. Dense forest receiving high rainfall
8. Everything around us, from air to water, animals to plants
9. Mutual relationship between two species
10. An environment near the equator with lush biodiversity
13. A community of interacting organisms and their environment
17. A living creature in an ecosystem

Abhi: Wow! This letter is an eye-opener,
Ammu! I really felt the emotion of the Chief's
voice!

Ammu: Me too, Abhi! We should protect
nature. If we protect nature, nature
protects us, remember?



*The Time Machine
beeps as it is
completely
recharged. They
change all the
settings, turn on the
switches, push the
buttons, and then,
pull the lever. The
time machine zooms
through time. When
the Time Machine
stops, Ammu and
Abhi look out of the
window.*

Ammu: Is this a room? It's very dark.

Abhi: (*Whispers*) Hey Ammu! Check the calendar
on the wall. 1875!

Ammu: God! What's all this!

Abhi: Look! A man is sitting in a chair downstairs,
and is writing something. Let's see what it is.

Invictus

William Ernest Henley

Poem

Out of the night that covers me,
 Black as the pit from pole to pole,
I thank whatever gods may be
 For my unconquerable soul.

In the fell clutch of circumstance
 I have not winced nor cried aloud.
Under the bludgeonings of chance
 My head is bloody, but unbowed.

Beyond this place of wrath and tears
 Looms but the Horror of the shade,
And yet the menace of the years
 Finds and shall find me unafraid.

It matters not how strait the gate,
 How charged with punishments the scroll,
I am the master of my fate,
 I am the captain of my soul.

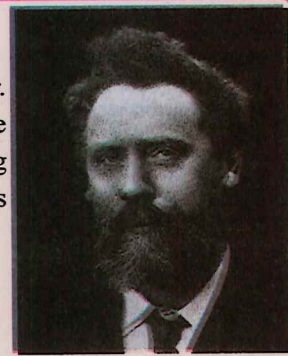
Theme Shopping for Students

Below are the key themes and objectives to learn from William Ernest Henley's "Invictus". As you understand each one, mark it off.

- ☐ Have you known who William Ernest Henley was, and what significant life experiences, like his health struggles, influenced his perspective?
- ☐ Have you understood how Henley's personal challenges shaped the themes and tone of "Invictus"?
- ☐ Can you explain the main themes of resilience, self-mastery, and inner strength in the poem?
- ☐ Have you understood the significance of phrases like "bloody, but unbowed" and "captain of my soul"?
- ☐ Can you summarize Henley's overall message about courage and personal responsibility in your own words?

About the Poet

William Ernest Henley (1849–1903) was an English poet, critic, and editor. He is best known for his poem “Invictus,” which he wrote while recovering from the amputation of his leg due to tuberculosis. Henley’s resilience in the face of suffering and his belief in individual strength and self-determination are central themes in his work.



Summary

“Invictus” by William Ernest Henley is a powerful poem about strength, courage, and determination in the face of difficulties. The title “Invictus” means “unconquered” in Latin, which reflects the main idea of the poem — that no matter how hard life gets, the speaker refuses to be defeated.

In the first stanza, the speaker talks about being surrounded by darkness and pain. Even though life is difficult and full of suffering, the speaker remains strong and does not lose hope. The “night” mentioned in the poem symbolizes the difficult and painful times in life, but the speaker says that he is not afraid because of his inner strength.

In the second stanza, the speaker explains that he has faced many challenges and hardships. Life has hurt him, but he has not bowed down to these difficulties. The phrase “bloody, but unbowed” means that even though circumstances have hurt him, he refuses to give up or lose his spirit.

In the third stanza, the speaker says that even though the future is uncertain and scary, he will face it bravely. The “Horror of the shade” represents the fear of death and the unknown, but the speaker says he will not let this fear control him.

In the final stanza, the speaker proudly declares that he is the “master of his fate” and the “captain of his soul.” This means that he is in control of his own life and decisions. No matter how hard life gets, he will stay strong and determined, without letting fate or bad luck define him.

The message of “Invictus” is about inner strength and courage. It teaches that even when life is difficult and painful, we have the power to choose how we respond and overcome those hurdles. The speaker reminds us that we can face any challenge with determination and remain unconquered.

Glossary

- **Bludgeonings** /ˈblʌdʒənɪŋz/ (noun): Hard hits or blows; represents life's challenges
Usage: The bludgeonings of life can be tough to handle.
- **Captain of my soul** /ˈkæptɪn əv maɪ soul/ (Phrase): Being in control of one's own life and choices
Usage: She believes she is the captain of her soul, steering her own path.
- **Charge with** /tʃɑːʒ wɪð/ (phrasal verb): Given responsibility or duty
Usage: She was charged with leading the project.
- **Circumstance** /ˈsɜː.kəm.stəns/ (noun): The situation or conditions
Usage: She overcame her difficult circumstances to succeed.
- **Horror** /ˈhɔːrər/ (noun): A strong feeling of fear or shock
Usage: The horror of the situation left them speechless.
- **Invictus** /ɪnˈvɪktəs/ (adjective): Unconquered; unable to be beaten
Usage: He felt invictus after overcoming his fears.
- **Loom** /luːm/ (verb): Appears or comes into view, often in a large way
Usage: The mountain looms in the distance, impressive and majestic.
- **Menace** /ˈmenɪs/ (noun): A threat or danger
Usage: The dark clouds were a menace to the picnic plans.
- **Pit** /pɪt/ (noun): A deep hole; symbolizes suffering
Usage: She felt as if she were in a pit of despair.
- **Scroll** /skrəʊl/ (noun): A long piece of paper with writing; symbolizes fate
Usage: The ancient scroll contained secrets of the past.
- **Strait** /streɪt/ (noun): A difficult situation; narrow or limited options
Usage: He found himself in a strait when he lost his job.
- **Unbowed** /ʌnˈbaʊd/ (adjective): Not defeated; standing tall
Usage: She remained unbowed despite the difficulties.
- **Unconquerable** /ʌnˈkɒŋkərəbəl/ (adjective): Impossible to defeat or overcome
Usage: Her unconquerable spirit inspired everyone around her.
- **Wince** /wɪns/ (verb): To make a slight movement of pain or discomfort; to flinch
Usage: He winced when he accidentally stubbed his toe.
- **Wrath** /ræθ/ (noun): Intense anger; strong feelings of being upset
Usage: The wrath of the storm frightened everyone.

Contextual Questions

Annotate the following lines in the given pattern

- a. Identify the lesson and name the poet of the given lines.
- b. Discuss the context of the lines and appreciate them critically in about 75 words.
 1. Out of the night that covers me,
Black as the pit from pole to pole.
 2. In the fell clutch of circumstance
I have not winced nor cried aloud.

3. I am the master of my fate,
I am the captain of my soul.
4. I thank whatever gods may be
For my unconquerable soul.

Questions

Answer the following questions in about 150 words each

1. How does the speaker's journey from darkness and struggle to self-mastery reflect the theme of resilience in the face of adversity?
2. In what ways does "Invictus" illustrate the importance of personal responsibility and inner strength in shaping one's destiny?

Creative Writing

Using the hints provided, write at least ten lines, expanding the ideas into complete sentences. Be creative!

Invincible Hope

Idea: Imagine that someone you care about has failed in their exams, and is feeling sad and hopeless. Encourage and inspire them to stay strong and to have hope

- Hints**
- Start with: "Dear friend, I know things are hard, but you are strong."
 - Say: "Remember when you _____?"
 - Give advice: "Take one step at a time, and I'm here for you."
 - End with: "I believe in you!"

1
Ammu: What is this fog? The pollution? It's suffocating! It feels worse than our times!

2
Abhi: In 1875, London is notorious for its pollution. It is! (Silence) Ammu, come, let's go home now.

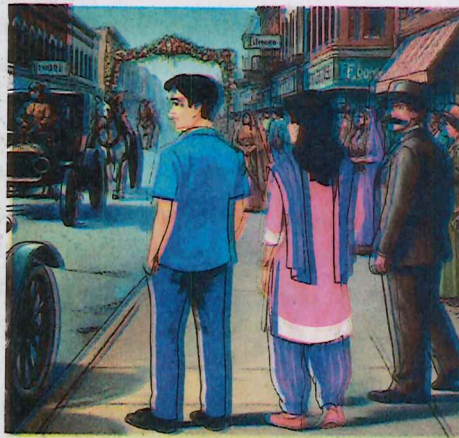
3
Ammu: Yes, let us go now! I miss home!



Abhi turns on the time machine. The machine makes noise for a long time and stops.

1
Ammu: Where are we now? God! Not definitely home. How many more stories does this machine want us to learn!

2
Abhi: This does not seem like the 21st century, Ammu. There's the American flag. Maybe we are in America, and in the past! Hey look, a wedding procession!



5
O. Henry: It's the wedding of none other than Jimmy Valentine! Don't tell me you've never heard of the legendary tale of Jimmy Valentine. If you haven't, you're in for a treat! Allow me the pleasure

4
Abhi: I'm Abhi, and this is Ammu. We're from India. Our vehicle's battery died, so we stopped here. It is being repaired. And... Whose wedding is this?

3
Henry: (Coming from behind) Well, hello there, young man and young lady. I'm O. Henry. You don't look like you're from Elmore. Did you happen to come for the wedding, perhaps?

A Retrieved Reformation

O. Henry

The Story

A GUARD CAME to the prison shoe-shop, where Jimmy Valentine was assiduously stitching uppers, and escorted him to the front office. There the warden handed Jimmy his pardon, which had been signed that morning by the governor. Jimmy took it in a tired kind of way. He had served nearly ten months of a four-year sentence. He had expected to stay only about three months, at the longest. When a man with as many friends on the outside as Jimmy Valentine had is received in the "stir" it is hardly worthwhile to cut his hair.

"Now, Valentine," said the warden, "you'll go out in the morning. Brace up, and make a man of yourself. You're not a bad fellow at heart. Stop cracking safes, and live straight."

"Me?" said Jimmy, in surprise. "Why, I never cracked a safe in my life."

"Oh, no," laughed the warden. "Of course not. Let's see, now. How was it you happened to get sent up on that Springfield job? Was it because you wouldn't prove an alibi for fear of compromising somebody in extremely high-toned society? Or was it simply a case of a mean old jury that had it in for you? It's always one or the other with you innocent victims."

"Me?" said Jimmy, still blankly virtuous. "Why, warden, I never was in Springfield in my life!"

"Take him back, Cronin!" said the warden, "and fix him up with outgoing clothes. Unlock him at seven in the morning, and let him come to the bull-pen. Better think over my advice, Valentine."

At a quarter past seven on the next morning Jimmy stood in the warden's outer office. He had on a suit of the villainously fitting, ready-made clothes and a pair of the stiff, squeaky shoes that the state furnishes to its discharged compulsory guests.

The clerk handed him a railroad ticket and the five-dollar bill with which the law expected him to rehabilitate himself into good citizenship and prosperity. The warden gave him a cigar, and shook hands. Valentine, 9762, was chronicled on the books "Pardoned by Governor," and Mr. James Valentine walked out into the sunshine.

Disregarding the song of the birds, the waving green trees, and the smell of the flowers, Jimmy headed straight for a restaurant. There he tasted the first sweet joys of liberty in the shape of a broiled chicken and a bottle of white wine—followed by a cigar a grade better than the one the warden had given him. From there he proceeded leisurely to the depot. He tossed a quarter into the hat of a blind man sitting by the door, and boarded his train. Three hours set him down in a little town near the state line. He went to the cafe of one Mike Dolan and shook hands with Mike, who was alone behind the bar.

"Sorry we couldn't make it sooner, Jimmy, me boy," said Mike. "But we had that protest from Springfield to buck against, and the governor nearly balked. Feeling all right?"

"Fine," said Jimmy. "Got my key?"

He got his key and went upstairs, unlocking the door of a room at the rear. Everything was just as he had left it. There on the floor was still Ben Price's collar-button that had been torn from that eminent detective's shirt-band when they had overpowered Jimmy to arrest him.

Pulling out from the wall a folding-bed, Jimmy slid back a panel in the wall and dragged out a dust-covered suit-case. He opened this and gazed fondly at the finest set of burglar's tools in the East. It was a complete set, made of specially tempered steel, the latest designs in drills, punches, braces and bits, jimmies, clamps, and augers, with two or three novelties, invented by Jimmy himself, in which he took pride. Over nine hundred dollars they had cost him to have made at—, a place where they make such things for the profession.

In half an hour Jimmy went downstairs and through the cafe. He was now dressed in tasteful and well-fitting clothes, and carried his dusted and cleaned suit-case in his hand.

"Got anything on?" asked Mike Dolan, genially.

"Me?" said Jimmy, in a puzzled tone. "I don't understand. I'm representing the New York Amalgamated Short Snap Biscuit Cracker and Frazzled Wheat Company."

This statement delighted Mike to such an extent that Jimmy had to take a seltzer-and-milk on the spot. He never touched "hard" drinks.

A week after the release of Valentine, 9762, there was a neat job of safe-burglary done in Richmond, Indiana, with no clue to the author. A scant eight hundred dollars was all that was secured. Two weeks after that a patented, improved, burglar-proof safe in Logansport was opened like a cheese to the tune of fifteen hundred dollars, currency; securities and silver untouched. That began to interest the rogue-catchers. Then an old-

fashioned bank-safe in Jefferson City became active and threw out of its crater an eruption of bank-notes amounting to five thousand dollars. The losses were now high enough to bring the matter up into Ben Price's class of work. By comparing notes, a remarkable similarity in the methods of the burglaries was noticed. Ben Price investigated the scenes of the robberies, and was heard to remark:

"That's Dandy Jim Valentine's autograph. He's resumed business. Look at that combination knob—jerked out as easy as pulling up a radish in wet weather. He's got the only clamps that can do it. And look how clean those tumblers were punched out! Jimmy never has to drill but one hole. Yes, I guess I want Mr. Valentine. He'll do his bit next time without any short-time or clemency foolishness."

Ben Price knew Jimmy's habits. He had learned them while working on the Springfield case. Long jumps, quick get-aways, no confederates, and a taste for good society—these ways had helped Mr. Valentine to become noted as a successful dodger of retribution. It was given out that Ben Price had taken up the trail of the elusive cracksman, and other people with burglar-proof safes felt more at ease.

One afternoon Jimmy Valentine and his suit-case climbed out of the mail-hack in Elmore, a little town five miles off the railroad down in the black-jack country of Arkansas. Jimmy, looking like an athletic young senior just home from college, went down the board side-walk toward the hotel.

A young lady crossed the street, passed him at the corner and entered a door over which was the sign "The Elmore Bank." Jimmy Valentine looked into her eyes, forgot what he was, and became another man. She lowered her eyes and colored slightly. Young men of Jimmy's style and looks were scarce in Elmore.

Jimmy collared a boy that was loafing on the steps of the bank as if he were one of the stockholders, and began to ask him questions about the town, feeding him dimes at intervals. By and by the young lady came out, looking royally unconscious of the young man with the suit-case, and went her way.

"Isn't that young lady Miss Polly Simpson?" asked Jimmy, with specious guile.

"Naw," said the boy. "She's Annabel Adams. Her pa owns this bank. What'd you come to Elmore for? Is that a gold watch-chain? I'm going to get a bulldog. Got any more dimes?"

Jimmy went to the Planters' Hotel, registered as Ralph D. Spencer, and engaged a room. He leaned on the desk and declared his platform to the clerk. He said he had come to Elmore to look for a location to go into business. How was the shoe business, now, in the town? He had thought of the shoe business. Was there an opening?

The clerk was impressed by the clothes and manner of Jimmy. He, himself, was something of a pattern of fashion to the thinly gilded youth of Elmore, but he now perceived his shortcomings. While trying to figure out Jimmy's manner of tying his four-in-hand he cordially gave information.

Yes, there ought to be a good opening in the shoe line. There wasn't an exclusive shoe-store in the place. The dry-goods and general stores handled them. Business in all lines was fairly good. Hoped Mr. Spencer would decide to locate in Elmore. He would find it a pleasant town to live in, and the people very sociable.

Mr. Spencer thought he would stop over in the town a few days and look over the situation. No, the clerk needn't call the boy. He would carry up his suit-case, himself; it was rather heavy.

Mr. Ralph Spencer, the phoenix that arose from Jimmy Valentine's ashes—ashes left by the flame of a sudden and alterative attack of love—remained in Elmore, and prospered. He opened a shoe-store and secured a good run of trade.

Socially he was also a success, and made many friends. And he accomplished the wish of his heart. He met Miss Annabel Adams, and became more and more captivated by her charms.

At the end of a year the situation of Mr. Ralph Spencer was this: he had won the respect of the community, his shoe-store was flourishing, and he and Annabel were engaged to be married in two weeks. Mr. Adams, the typical, plodding, country banker, approved of Spencer. Annabel's pride in him almost equalled her affection. He was as much at home in the family of Mr. Adams and that of Annabel's married sister as if he were already a member.

One day Jimmy sat down in his room and wrote this letter, which he mailed to the safe address of one of his old friends in St. Louis:

Dear Old Pal:

I want you to be at Sullivan's place, in Little Rock, next Wednesday night, at nine o'clock. I want you to wind up some little matters for me. And, also, I want to make you a present of my kit of tools. I know you'll be glad to get them—you couldn't duplicate the lot for a thousand dollars. Say, Billy, I've quit the old business—a year ago. I've got a nice store. I'm making an honest living, and I'm going to marry the finest girl on earth two weeks from now. It's the only life, Billy—the straight one. I wouldn't touch a dollar of another man's money now for a million. After I get married I'm going to sell out and go West, where there won't be so much danger of having old scores brought up against me. I tell you, Billy, she's

an angel. She believes in me; and I wouldn't do another crooked thing for the whole world. Be sure to be at Sully's, for I must see you. I'll bring along the tools with me.

*Your old friend,
Jimmy.*

Pause and Ponder

Ammu: Did you read that letter, Abhi? Jimmy really changed!

On the Monday night after Jimmy wrote this letter, Ben Price jogged unobtrusively into Elmore in a livery buggy. He lounged about town in his quiet way until he found out what he wanted to know. From the drug-store across the street from Spencer's shoe-store he got a good look at Ralph D. Spencer.

"Going to marry the banker's daughter are you, Jimmy?" said Ben to himself, softly. "Well, I don't know!"

The next morning Jimmy took breakfast at the Adamses. He was going to Little Rock that day to order his wedding-suit and buy something nice for Annabel. That would be the first time he had left town since he came to Elmore. It had been more than a year now since those last professional "jobs," and he thought he could safely venture out.

After breakfast quite a family party went downtown together—Mr. Adams, Annabel, Jimmy, and Annabel's married sister with her two little girls, aged five and nine. They came by the hotel where Jimmy still boarded, and he ran up to his room and brought along his suit-case. Then they went on to the bank. There stood Jimmy's horse and buggy and Dolph Gibson, who was going to drive him over to the railroad station.

All went inside the high, carved oak railings into the banking-room—Jimmy included, for Mr. Adams's

future son-in-law was welcome anywhere. The clerks were pleased to be greeted by the good-looking, agreeable young man who was going to marry Miss Annabel. Jimmy set his suit-case down. Annabel, whose heart was bubbling with happiness and lively youth, put on Jimmy's hat, and picked up the suit-case. "Wouldn't I make a nice drummer?" said Annabel. "My! Ralph, how heavy it is. Feels like it was full of gold bricks."

"Lot of nickel-plated shoe-horns in there," said Jimmy, coolly, "that I'm going to return. Thought I'd save express charges by taking them up. I'm getting awfully economical."

The Elmore Bank had just put in a new safe and vault. Mr. Adams was very proud of it, and insisted on an inspection by everyone. The vault was a small one, but it had a new, patented door. It fastened with three solid steel bolts thrown simultaneously with a single handle, and had a time-lock. Mr. Adams beamingly explained its workings to Mr. Spencer, who showed a courteous but not too intelligent interest. The two children, May and Agatha, were delighted by the shining metal and funny clock and knobs.

While they were thus engaged Ben Price sauntered in and leaned on his elbow, looking casually inside between the railings. He told the teller that he didn't want anything; he was just waiting for a man he knew.

Suddenly there was a scream or two from the women, and a commotion. Unperceived by the elders, May, the nine-year-old girl, in a spirit of play, had shut Agatha in the vault. She had then shot the bolts and turned the knob of the combination as she had seen Mr. Adams do.

The old banker sprang to the handle and tugged at it for a moment. "The door can't be opened," he groaned. "The clock hasn't been wound nor the combination set."

Agatha's mother screamed again, hysterically.

"Hush!" said Mr. Adams, raising his trembling hand. "All be quite for a moment. Agatha!" he called as loudly as he could. "Listen to me." During the following silence they could just hear the faint sound of the child wildly shrieking in the dark vault in a panic of terror.

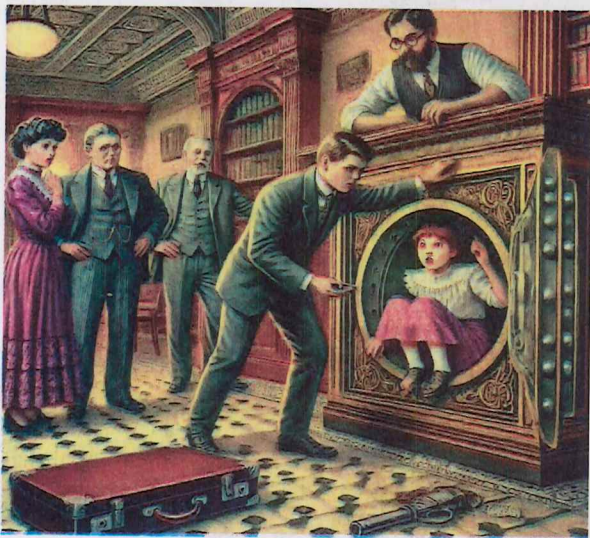
"My precious darling!" wailed the mother. "She will die of fright! Open the door! Oh, break it open! Can't you men do something?"

"There isn't a man nearer than Little Rock who can open that door," said Mr. Adams, in a shaky voice. "My God! Spencer, what shall we do? That child—she can't stand it long in there. There isn't enough air, and, besides, she'll go into convulsions from fright."

Agatha's mother, frantic now, beat the door of the vault with her hands. Somebody wildly suggested dynamite. Annabel turned to Jimmy, her large eyes full of anguish, but not yet despairing. To a woman nothing seems quite impossible to the powers of the man she worships.

"Can't you do something, Ralph—try, won't you?"

He looked at her with a queer, soft smile on his lips and in his keen eyes.



"Annabel," he said, "give me that rose you are wearing, will you?"

Hardly believing that she heard him aright, she unpinned the bud from the bosom of her dress, and placed it in his hand. Jimmy stuffed it into his vest-pocket, threw off his coat and pulled up his shirt-sleeves. With that act Ralph D. Spencer passed away and Jimmy Valentine took his place.

"Get away from the door, all of you," he commanded, shortly.

He set his suit-case on the table, and opened it out flat. From that time on he seemed to be unconscious of the presence of anyone else. He laid out the shining, queer implements swiftly and orderly, whistling softly to himself as he always did when at work. In a deep silence and immovable, the others watched him as if under a spell.

In a minute Jimmy's pet drill was biting smoothly into the steel door. In ten minutes—breaking his own burglarious record—he threw back the bolts and opened the door.

Agatha, almost collapsed, but safe, was gathered into her mother's arms.

Jimmy Valentine put on his coat, and walked outside the railings toward the front door. As he went he thought he heard a far-away voice that he once knew call "Ralph!" But he never hesitated.

At the door a big man stood somewhat in his way.

"Hello, Ben!" said Jimmy, still with his strange smile. "Got around at last, have you? Well, let's go. I don't know that it makes much difference, now."

And then Ben Price acted rather strangely.

"Guess you're mistaken, Mr. Spencer," he said. "Don't believe I recognize you. Your buggy's waiting for you, ain't it?"

And Ben Price turned and strolled down the street.

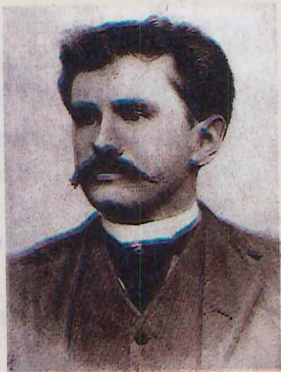
Theme Unlock for Students

Below are the key themes and objectives to learn from O. Henry "A Retrieved Reformation". As you understand each one, mark it off.

- Can you think about what it takes for a person to change their ways and why it might be difficult?
- Have you ever reflected on how love and trust can inspire transformation in someone's life?
- Can you identify instances in real life or fiction where someone got a second chance and made the most of it?
- Have you thought about the role of forgiveness in resolving conflicts and building relationships?
- Can you talk about how small choices can lead to significant transformations?

About the Author

O. Henry (1862–1910), whose real name was William Sydney Porter, was an American short story writer known for his wit, wordplay, and twist endings. His works often depict ordinary people in extraordinary situations, blending humour with deeper reflections on human nature. A master storyteller, O. Henry wrote over 300 short stories, many of which explore themes of love, sacrifice, and redemption. Despite facing personal challenges, including imprisonment for embezzlement, he used his experiences to craft stories that continue to captivate readers worldwide.



Summary

"A Retrieved Reformation" is one of O. Henry's most celebrated short stories, first published in 1903. Set in a small town in America, the story highlights themes of redemption, love, and the transformative power of second chances. It follows Jimmy Valentine, a skilled safecracker who is released from prison after serving a sentence for burglary. Despite the warden's advice to reform, Jimmy returns to his old habits and commits several burglaries soon after his release.

While on the run, Jimmy arrives in the small town of Elmore, Arkansas, where he meets Annabel Adams, the daughter of the local banker. Falling in love with Annabel, Jimmy decides to abandon his criminal past and start a new life. He assumes a new identity as Ralph D. Spencer and opens a successful shoe store in Elmore. Over time, he gains the respect of the townspeople and becomes engaged to Annabel.

Jimmy's past catches up with him when Ben Price, a detective familiar with Jimmy's methods, arrives in town, determined to arrest him. On the day Jimmy is planning to leave for Little Rock to buy his wedding suit, a crisis occurs at the bank. Annabel's young niece accidentally locks her sister in the new vault, which cannot be opened without a combination or time lock.

Realizing the girl's life is in danger, Jimmy is faced with a difficult choice. He decides to use his safecracking skills to open the vault and save the child, even though it will expose his true identity and likely lead to his arrest. After successfully opening the vault and saving the girl, Jimmy prepares to turn himself in to Ben Price. Moved by Jimmy's selfless act and his evident transformation, Ben Price decides to let him go, pretending not to recognise him, thus allowing Jimmy to continue his new life.

The story highlights themes of redemption, the redemptive power of love, and the possibility of starting anew for anyone and everyone.

Glossary

- **Alibi** /'ælibaɪ/ (**noun**): A claim or proof that one was elsewhere when a crime occurred
Usage: He presented an alibi to prove he was not at the scene of the crime.
- **Anguish** /'æŋɡwɪʃ/ (**noun**): Severe mental or physical pain or suffering
Usage: She was in great anguish after hearing the heartbreaking news.
- **Beamingly** /'bi:mɪŋli/ (**adverb**): Smiling brightly or happily
Usage: The proud mother smiled beamingly at her child's graduation ceremony.
- **Brace Up** /breɪs ʌp/ (**Phrasal Verb**): To strengthen oneself or prepare for something difficult
Usage: Brace up! We've got a lot of work ahead.
- **Chronicle** /'krɒnɪkl/ (**verb**): Recorded in a factual and detailed way
Usage: The journalist chronicled the events of the war in his memoir.
- **Collapse** /kə'ləps/ (**verb**): Fell down or gave way suddenly
Usage: The old building collapsed after the heavy rain.
- **Commotion** /kə'məʊʃn/ (**noun**): A state of noisy confusion or disturbance
Usage: The sudden commotion in the classroom startled the teacher.
- **Compromising** /'kɒmprəmaɪzɪŋ/ (**adjective**): Exposing someone to suspicion or risk of disgrace
Usage: He was caught in a compromising situation at work.
- **Convulsions** /kən'vʌlʃnz/ (**noun**): Sudden, violent, uncontrollable movements of the body
Usage: The patient experienced convulsions before being rushed to the hospital.
- **Courteous** /'kɜ:tɪəs/ (**adjective**): Polite and respectful in behaviour
Usage: The receptionist was courteous and helpful to all visitors.
- **Crooked** /'krʊkɪd/ (**adjective**): Dishonest or illegal; also means bent or twisted out of shape
Usage: The crooked politician was exposed in a corruption scandal.
- **Elusive** /ɪ'lu:sɪv/ (**adjective**): Difficult to find, catch, or achieve
Usage: The solution to the puzzle remained elusive despite their efforts.
- **Fastened** /'fɑ:snd/ (**verb**): Securely attached or closed
Usage: She fastened her seatbelt before the car started moving.
- **Frantic** /'fræntɪk/ (**adjective**): Wild or panicked due to fear or worry
Usage: He made a frantic search for his lost wallet.
- **Genially** /'dʒi:niəli/ (**adverb**): In a friendly and cheerful manner
Usage: He greeted everyone genially at the party.
- **Groaned** /grəʊnd/ (**verb**): Made a low sound of pain, discomfort, or displeasure
Usage: The injured man groaned as he tried to stand up.
- **Panic** /'pæntɪk/ (**noun**): Sudden, overwhelming fear
Usage: The fire alarm caused panic among the office workers.
- **Pardon** /'pɑ:dn/ (**noun**): Forgiveness for a mistake or wrongdoing
Usage: The president granted a pardon to the convicted criminal.
- **Plodding** /'plɒdɪŋ/ (**adjective**): Moving or working slowly and steadily
Usage: He kept plodding through the dense forest despite his exhaustion.

- **Protest** /ˈprəʊtest/ (noun): A statement or action expressing disapproval or objection
Usage: The students staged a protest at the entrance gate of the university.
- **Rehabilitate** /ri:(h)əˈbɪlɪteɪt/ (verb): Restore someone to normal life through training or therapy
Usage: The program aims to rehabilitate prisoners into society.
- **Retribution** /retrɪˈbjʊ:ʃn/ (noun): Punishment inflicted as vengeance for a wrong or crime
Usage: The villain faced retribution for his actions in the end.
- **Retrieved** /rɪˈtri:vd/ (verb): To get or bring something back from a place or condition
Usage: The lost document was finally retrieved from the damaged computer.
- **Reformation** /refərˈmeɪʃn/ (noun): The process of improving or correcting what is wrong, corrupt, or unsatisfactory. It often refers to a complete transformation or significant change in character or structure.
Usage: The reformation of the criminal led to his becoming an honest man.
- **Sentence** /ˈsentəns/ (noun): The punishment assigned to a convicted person by a court
Usage: The judge announced a five-year sentence for the accused.
- **Shrieking** /ˈʃri:kɪŋ/ (verb): Making a loud, high-pitched cry
Usage: The children were shrieking with laughter as they played.
- **Squeaky** /ˈskwi:ki/ (adjective): Making a high-pitched, shrill sound
Usage: The old door opened with a loud, squeaky noise.
- **Trail** /treɪl/ (noun): A path or track
Usage: The hikers followed the mountain trail to the summit.
- **Vault** /vɔ:lt/ (noun): A secure room used for storing valuables, such as in a bank
Usage: The gold bars were safely locked away in the bank vault.
- **Virtuous** /ˈvɜ:tʃuəs/ (adjective): Having or showing high moral standards
Usage: He was admired for his virtuous character and honesty.

Essay Questions

Answer the following questions in about 300 words each

1. Write a detailed character sketch of Jimmy Valentine, highlighting his evolution from a skilled criminal to a reformed gentleman.
2. What moral lessons can be drawn from “A Retrieved Reformation”? How does the story convey the ideas of redemption, forgiveness, and the possibility of change?

Creative Writing

Using the hints provided, write at least ten lines, expanding the ideas into complete sentences. Be creative!

1. An Apology Letter to Yourself

Idea: Write a letter to yourself, apologise for something you regret, like not studying properly for an exam. In the letter, explain why you are sorry, and promise to do better in future. Reflect on how you can improve and what steps you'll take to make things right.

- Hints**
1. Dear Me, I'm writing to apologize for
 2. I feel I didn't give my best effort, and
 3. I will make a plan to study
 4. I will ask teachers for help
 1. I will try harder and

2. The Magic Door

Idea: Imagine you find a magic door in your home. This door leads to an amazing world filled with magical creatures, strange landscapes, or fantastic objects. Write a story about what you find behind the door. What do you see, hear, and feel? Is there anything that surprises you? How does this adventure change you?

- Hints**
1. I accidentally found a magical door in my grandparents' house
 2. As the door opened, I saw (describe creatures, objects, or landscapes)
 3. I could hear (describe sounds like birds singing, wind blowing, or magical noises)
 4. I found several creatures and animals facing a problem (describe a problem that is faced by many creatures and animals in that world).
 5. I wanted to help them by (describe how you helped them and made it a better world).

Classroom Activity

Debate on Moral Dilemma

Divide the class into two groups. One group argues that Ben Price was right to let Jimmy go because he had genuinely reformed and deserved a second chance. The other group argues that Price should have arrested Jimmy to uphold the law and ensure justice. Encourage students to use evidence from the story to support their arguments. After the debate, hold a class discussion on forgiveness versus accountability and its relevance in real life.

Ammu and Abhi: Thanks, Mr. Henry. We won't forget this story.

O. Henry: As will I, my friends. The tales we carry in our hearts often reveal the best parts of ourselves. Treasure them. They'll guide you when you need them most.

Ammu: You put things beautifully, Mr. Henry. And, I think it is time for us to leave.

O. Henry: Ah, but you mustn't leave just yet! It wouldn't do to miss Jimmy's wedding. Come now, my young friends, let's find you some proper attire for the occasion, and I shall have the pleasure of introducing you to the groom himself!

Ammu: A new dress?!



UNIT 3

Brave New World